

— PARENT INTELLIGENCE REPORT

5 simple ways to grow a late talking child's words

Worried about a late talking child? Learn what's normal, the milestones to watch, and how to gently grow your child's words — plus why even Einstein spoke late.

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THE CHALLENGE PARENTS FACE

You're at a birthday party. Another toddler the same age as yours is chatting in little sentences. Your child points and grunts. Your stomach drops. If you have a late talking child, you know that quiet panic well — the comparing, the late-night searching, the worry you're missing something.

THE 30-SECOND ANSWER

5 simple ways to grow a late talking child's words

QUICK ANSWER

What is a late talking child? A late talking child is a toddler who is slow to start using words but is otherwise developing normally — playing, understanding, and connecting well. Specialists call this "late language emergence." It affects about 10–15% of toddlers, and many catch up on their own or with simple support at home.

WHAT THE RESEARCH SHOWS

AAAP-backed research shows that rich, back-and-forth conversation early on is linked to stronger language skills and even higher IQ scores at school age.

Sources: CDC

DO THIS

5 simple ways to grow a late talking child's words

Work through these in order. Small, consistent reps beat one big push.

1**Narrate the day out loud**

"We're washing the red cup. Warm water!" Words stick when they match what your child sees.

2**Pause and wait**

Ask "Want up?", then count to five in your head. Silence gives your child room to try a sound.

3**Add one word to theirs**

They say "car"; you say "fast car!" You're showing the next step, not correcting.

4**Read the same picture book daily and let them fill the gap**

"The cow says...?" Repetition builds first words.

5**Cut background screens and TV**

Real back-and-forth talk with you beats any app for building language.

— KEEP AN EYE OUT

Milestones to watch (and when to get help)

- ✓ By 12 months: babbles, tries a word or two, points and gestures to share.
- ✓ By 18 months: uses several single words and follows a simple instruction.
- ✓ By 24 months: says about 50 words and joins two together ("want ball").
- ✓ Green flag at any age: your child understands you well, makes eye contact, and connects — comprehension often comes before speech.

— COMMON QUESTIONS

Quick answers for parents

Should I worry about my late talking child if they understand everything?

Good comprehension is a reassuring sign. A child who understands you, makes eye contact, and uses gestures is connecting well, even if words are slow. Keep talking with them and watch the milestones — but strong understanding usually means the words are on their way.

When should a late talking child see a doctor?

Talk to your doctor if your child is losing words they once used, not responding to their name, not pointing or gesturing, or not connecting with you. Also check in if they have very few words by age two. Early speech help is simple and effective, so it's always okay to ask.

Did Einstein really talk late?

According to several biographers, Einstein was slow to speak as a young child and his family worried. The story is well known enough that some doctors use the term "Einstein syndrome" for bright children who talk late. It's a comforting reminder that a slow start doesn't decide a child's future.

Can screens cause a speech delay?

Screens don't replace what builds language: real, back-and-forth talk with a caring adult. Heavy background TV and passive app time can crowd out that conversation. Cutting screens and adding more face-to-face chatting is one of the simplest ways to help words grow.

How can I help my toddler talk more at home?

Narrate your day, pause to give them a turn, add one word to whatever they say, and read the same picture books often. Tie words to what your child cares about in the moment. These small, daily habits grow language faster than any flashcard.

Will a late talker catch up?

Many late talkers do catch up to their peers by the early school years, especially with rich talk at home and early help if needed. Every child is different, so watch the milestones — but a late start is common and often temporary.

READING HELPS. PRACTICE STICKS.

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